have not changed since then is to dismiss the considerable achievements that India has to its record since the 1990s. It is also to underplay India's visibly improved standing in the world.

In the past, we drew a line when it came to make or break issues like the CTBT or TRIPS. Today, India has both the ability to work confidently with the West when required and differ with it when its interests so demand. Afghanistan, Iran, Russia, climate change, connectivity or terrorism are some relevant examples. Nor did India hesitate to chart its own course when occasion arose in regions like Africa. In its own neighbourhood, there has not only been a willingness to take positions, but also some ability to influence the international community by doing so. This may make it uncomfortably independent at times, but still a partner that has growing value in a more multiaxial world.

While Indians look at the future with confidence, they should not forget that the journey ahead has obstacles of history to surmount. Although it made very substantial contributions in the First and Second World Wars, India was not on the high table in 1945 and continues to pay the price of being absent. Underlining its sacrifices in these wars and subsequent peacekeeping operations is part of the endeavour to make its claims more forcefully. For all the talk of a more contemporary world order, it is evident that the entrenched powers will not readily give up their privileges, even if that means a more dysfunctional international system. Practices and regimes that derive from 1945 impinge on India negatively, whether it is the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty or, till recently, representation in the International Court of Justice. Questioning the 1945 order is important but a task to be handled with considerable delicacy. It should be done with a forward-looking perspective that would appeal to the decolonized world, rather than be seen as a backward step that reverses historical outcomes. As India goes up in the international order, it will advance its own narratives, and, on occasion, question Western ones.

The fact that India is a working democracy established under the most challenging conditions should hold some clues to its nature. Whether this pluralism emanates from more recent political experiences or is an inherent cultural attribute is irrelevant. There is a sufficiently long record to suggest